# Affordable Indulgence.

## Small joys, big shifts: How SA spends when budgets tighten.

Prepared for Commercial & Brand Leaders

# The paradox: cut big, keep small

**People are ditching dinners out but protecting their chocolate fix.**

Big expenses like dining and appliances get the axe first.

But the **treat fund is ring-fenced**

**Low cost, high reward, totally repeatable.**

**8 in 10** are keeping their small joys, even when the budget bleeds.

# The treat fund is untouchable

**Consumers are ditching big spending, but protecting their daily joy.**

Aggregated data shows a massive shift: people are cutting high-ticket items to fiercely protect the small moments that keep them sane.

## 8 in 10

always make room for treats, no matter the budget.

## 3 in 4

say small daily treats = emotional wellbeing.

## 8 in 10

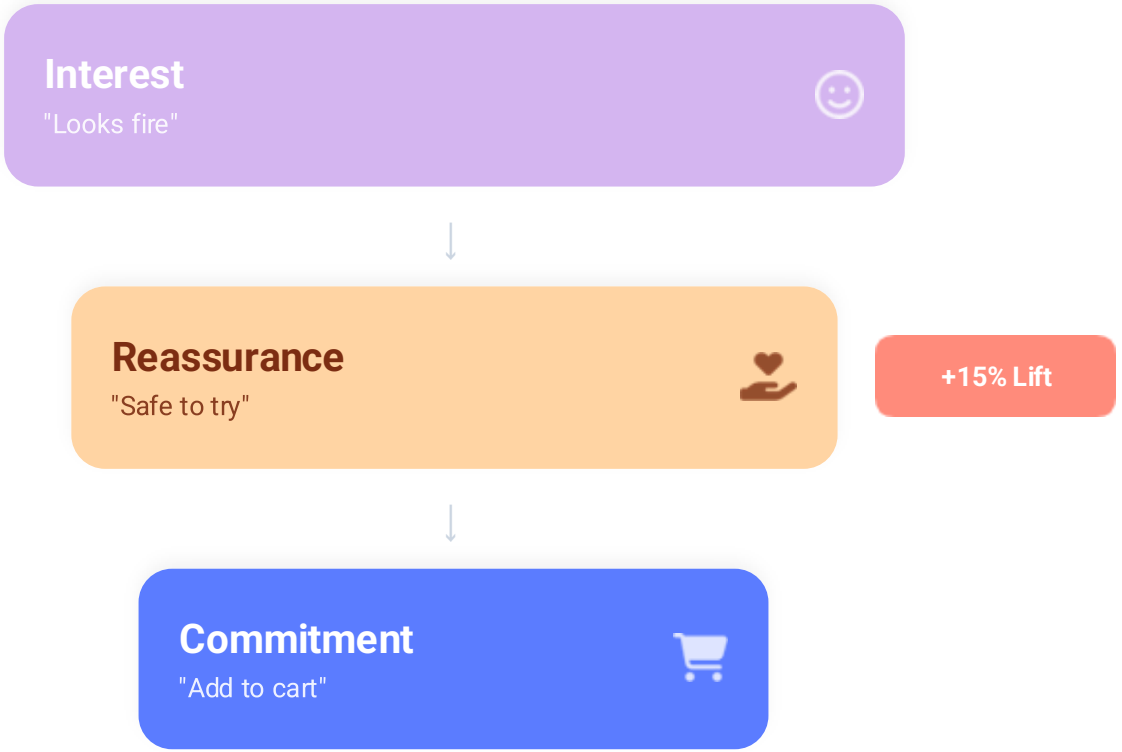
cut restaurants & big luxuries, not their snack fix.

# Inspire me → Reassure me

**Interest is easy. Commitment needs permission.**

Aspiration gets the "like". Reassurance gets the sale. When budgets are tight, "cool" isn't enough. We need to know it's a safe bet before we tap to pay.

- Permission cues > Pure Hype.
- Portion caps = financial safety nets.
- Reassurance adds +15 points to commitment.



Section 2

# What the data actually shows

- High ticket = hesitation
- Small + Premium = Repeat buys
- Nostalgia is a cheat code
- Entry-level wins the trial game
- More moments > Bigger baskets

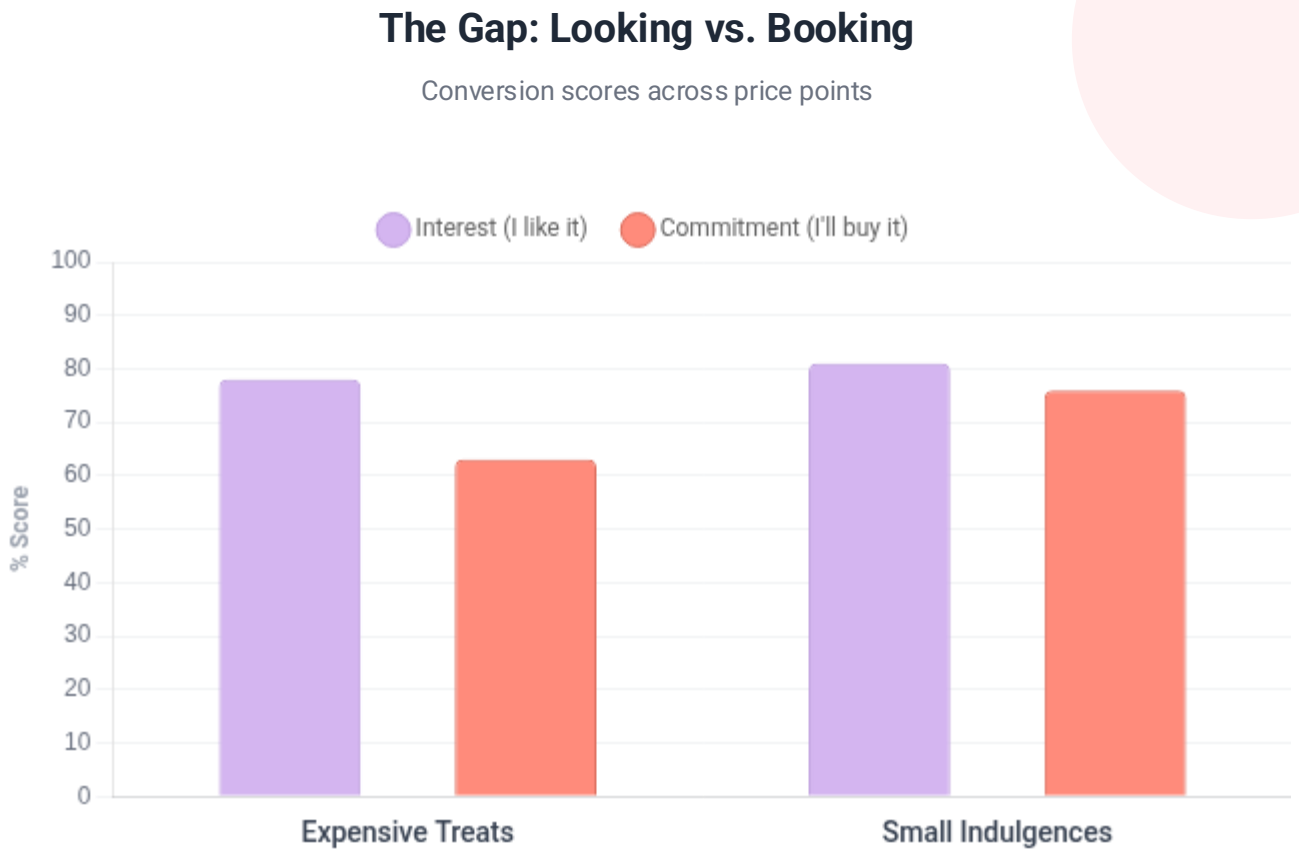
# Interest ≠ Buying

**People like expensive treats but don't commit to them.**

We all want the premium bundle, but sticker shock stops the swipe. High-ticket items get the hype (Interest), but wallet-friendly treats actually get the sale (Commitment).

**10-15 pt**

The "Sticker Shock" Drop-off




*Source: Aggregated Innovatr Concept Screens 2026*

# Small + Premium Wins

## Give me fancy in bite-size.

Smaller premium formats deliver a better balance of "feel-good" and financial safety. In benchmarks, they consistently outperform larger "value packs" on declared repeat intent, even when the price per gram is higher.

People are willing to pay a premium for control—avoiding the high upfront cost of bulk buying while still accessing quality.

**+12 pts**

**Repeat Advantage for Small Premium Formats**

### Repeat Intent Comparison

Small Premium vs. Large Value Packs

Source: Aggregated Innovatr Concept Benchmarks 2026

# Nostalgia is the cheat code

## Old school cool pays off.

Bringing back childhood faves isn't lazy—it's lucrative. In a chaotic world, familiar flavours and retro vibes offer emotional safety that novelty just can't match. It's the "I know this won't suck" factor.

**7 in 10**

**Pay for Faves**

Consumers explicitly say they'd pay extra to bring back a childhood favorite.

**+2 Digits**

**Commitment Lift**

Familiar flavours = double-digit growth. Novelty gets looks; nostalgia gets buys.

**High**

**Emotional Safety**

When life is unpredictable, a familiar treat feels like a hug. Low risk, high reward.

# Step-in beats step-change

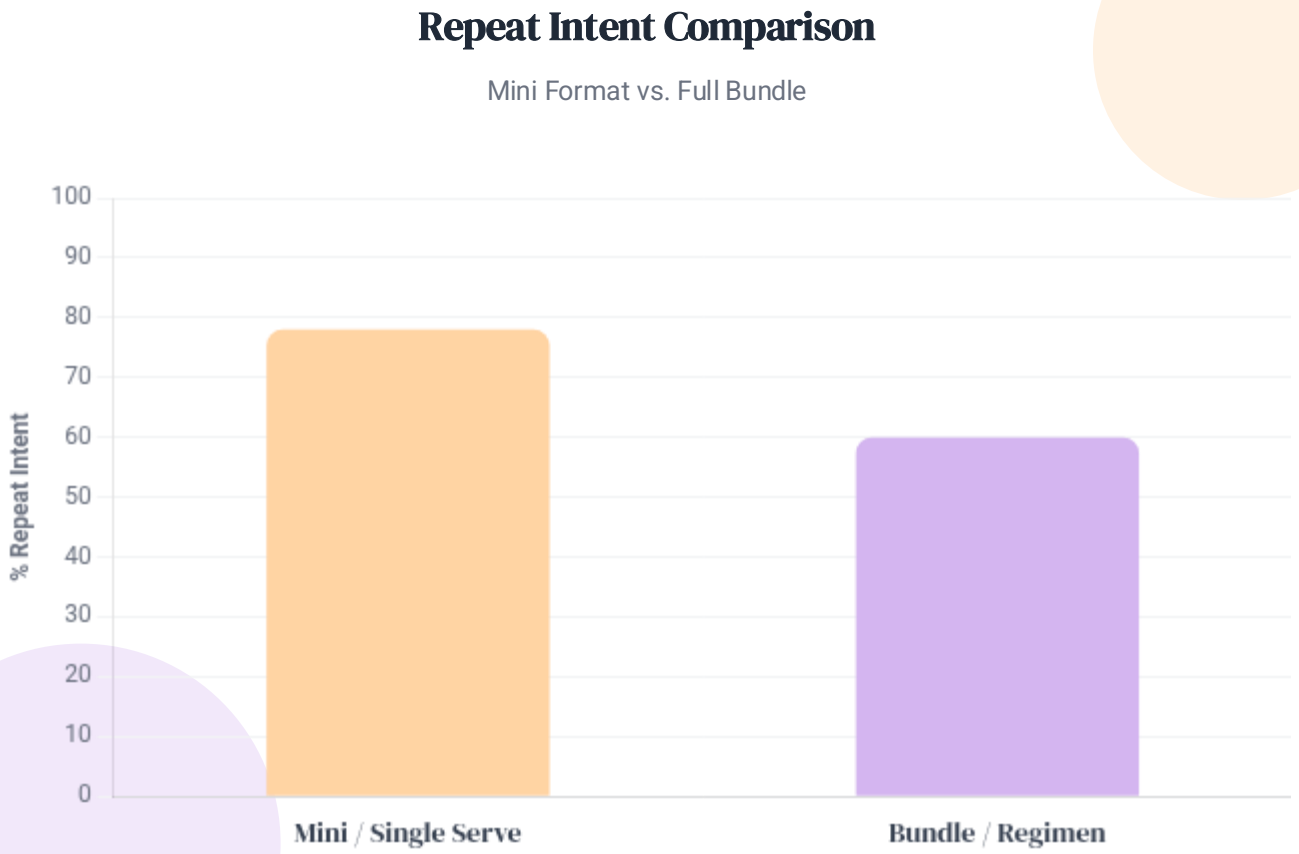
## Upgrade the moment, not the whole month.

Entry-level treats and mini formats win. Full-routine upgrades asking for big commitment? Hard pass.

Interest levels are same-same, but repeat buys skew heavily to the accessible stuff. People want to dip a toe in, not dive.

**+18 pts**

**Repeat Gap (Mini vs. Bundle)**




*Source: Aggregated Innovatr Concept Benchmarks 2026*

# More moments > bigger baskets

**Frequent small wins beat one big splurge.**

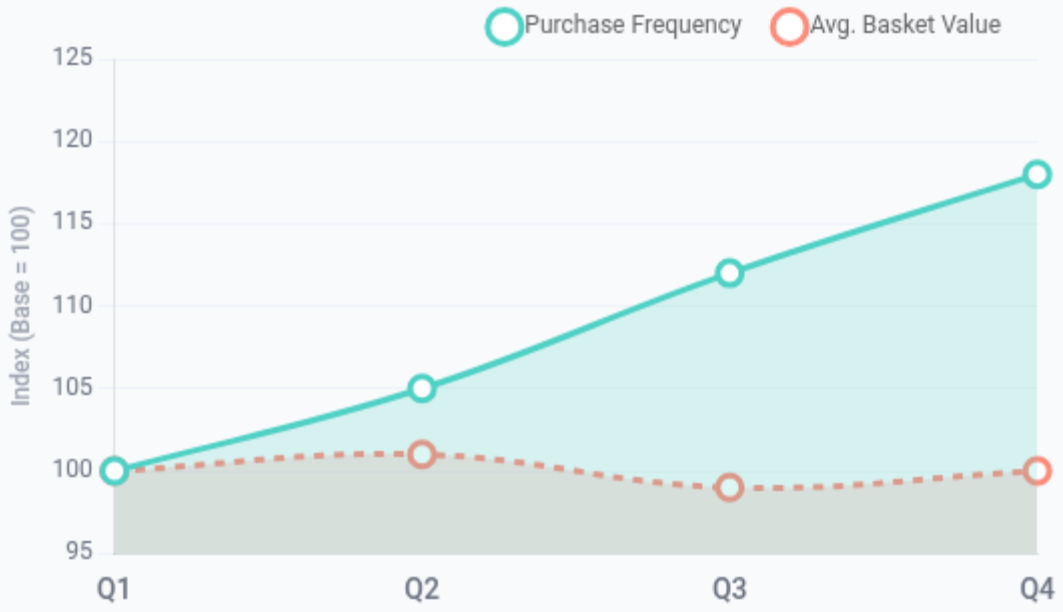
Purchase frequency is edging up. Basket value is flat. People want many affordable peaks, not one expensive spike.

Trading high-ticket commitment for **frequent emotional lifts.**

**More than half** use loyalty rewards to fuel repeat treats.

Growth comes from more usage occasions, not bigger buys.

**Purchase Cadence: Frequency vs. Value**




*Source: Innovatr Multi-Category Tracking 2026*

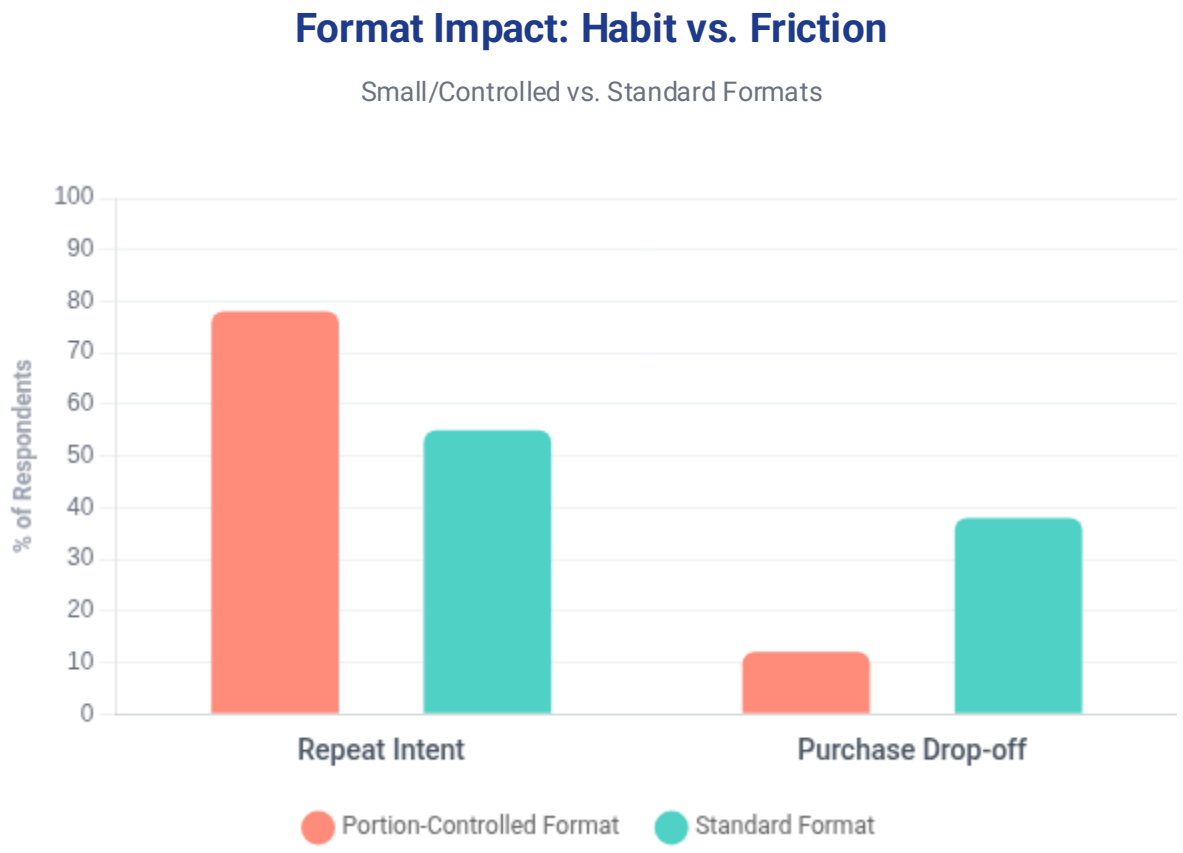
# Portion control = permission

**Smaller size, bigger repeat.**

Minis, pocket sizes, and trial kits reduce the risk. They create daily rituals that stick because the "stop signal" is baked right into the pack.

Format-driven permission lowers the barrier to entry. People buy again because it feels safe, not sinful.

**64%** Prefer snacks that allow enjoyment without overdoing it




*Source: Aggregated Innovatr Category Screens 2026*

Section 3

# Why SA hits different

Five local amplifiers reinforce the need for small joy:

- Income Volatility
- Inflation Fatigue
- Weekly Unpredictability
- Emotional Load
- Energy Instability

# Money's Tight, Choices Are Tight

**Half of us cover only basics—treats need to be defendable.**

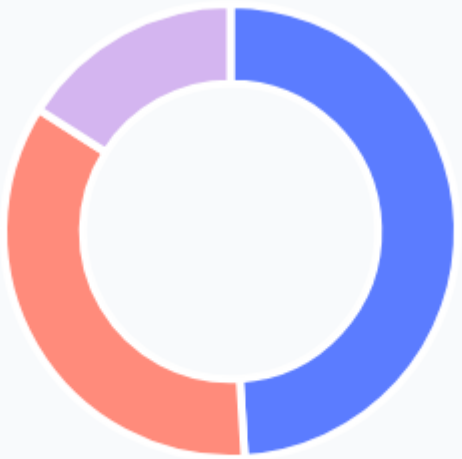
With many supporting extended family, discretionary choices must be fiercely justified. Small treats pass the "defendable" test far easier than big upgrades.

**49%** say income barely covers essentials.

Loyalty points are now a survival tool, not a bonus.

Treats act as 'allowable' rewards in a tight month.

**Where the Money Goes**



Essentials Only · Some Wiggle Room · Comfortable

Source: Innovatr Household Dynamics 2026

# Inflation fatigue is real

## Consumers optimize spending without abandoning joy.

After years of high prices, consumers have become strategic value-hackers. They aggressively use loyalty rewards, promotions, and smart trade-downs to free up budget for the small pleasures that matter.

**>50%**

### Rewards Usage

Half use rewards to stretch rands.

**49%**

### Basics Only

Report having only enough income for essentials, driving creative trade-down behavior to store brands.

**74%**

### Trust Critical

Trust still matters.

# Unpredictable weeks = controlled treats

**Minis fit the cash envelope reality.**

When the budget zig-zags, we crave treats that stay steady. Single-serve formats mean fixed costs and zero "oops I spent too much" regret.

- We're finding **"smaller, cheaper ways"** to reward ourselves.
- One pack = one price. No mental math required.
- It's predictable joy for an unpredictable week.

## The "Safe Spend" Moments

### Commute Snack

Low-cost transition before/after the grind.

### Desk Break

Reclaiming energy without leaving the office.

### Kids' Lunchbox

Guaranteed joy that fits the daily budget.

Source: Innovatr Occasion Mapping 2026

# We're emotionally tired

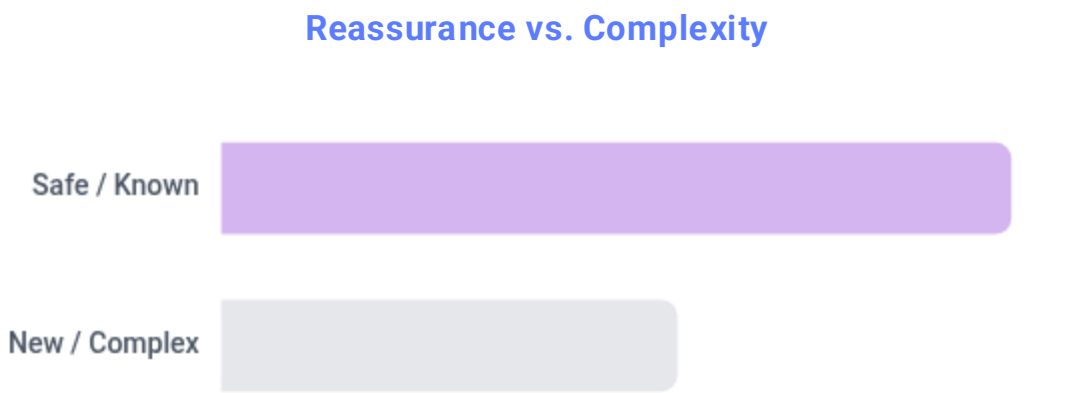
## Known > risky.

Safe, familiar wins. When energy is low, complicated ideas get skipped.

We want decisions that feel safe, not like homework.

Familiarity is the ultimate shortcut to trust.

**3 in 4** say small treats = mental health support.




**Taste We Know**
No surprises.

**Safe Sizes**
Guilt-free limits.

**Chill Vibes**
Soft & simple.

Source: Innovatr Concept Testing 2026

# Loadshedding reshapes joy

## No power? Portable treats win.

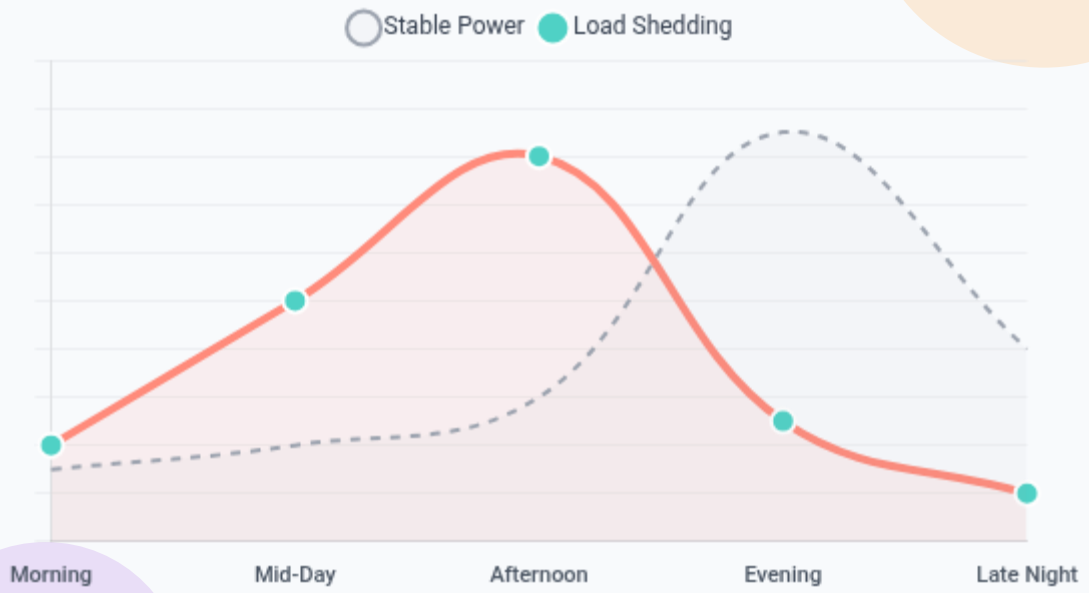
When the lights go out, habits flip. We're ditching the oven and eating earlier.

**Timing shift:** Evening chill-out is out. Afternoon "safe zones" are in.

**Format swap:** If it needs a microwave, it stays on the shelf. Ready-to-eat rules.

**Single-serve spikes:** Quick, portable hits for chaotic schedules.

### Indulgence timing flips to daylight




*Source: Innovatr Daypart Tracking 2026*

Section 4

# Where brands mess up

- Expensive stuff makes people hesitate
- Hype launches with zero habit
- Bulk buying kills the daily vibe
- Discounts ≠ Loyalty

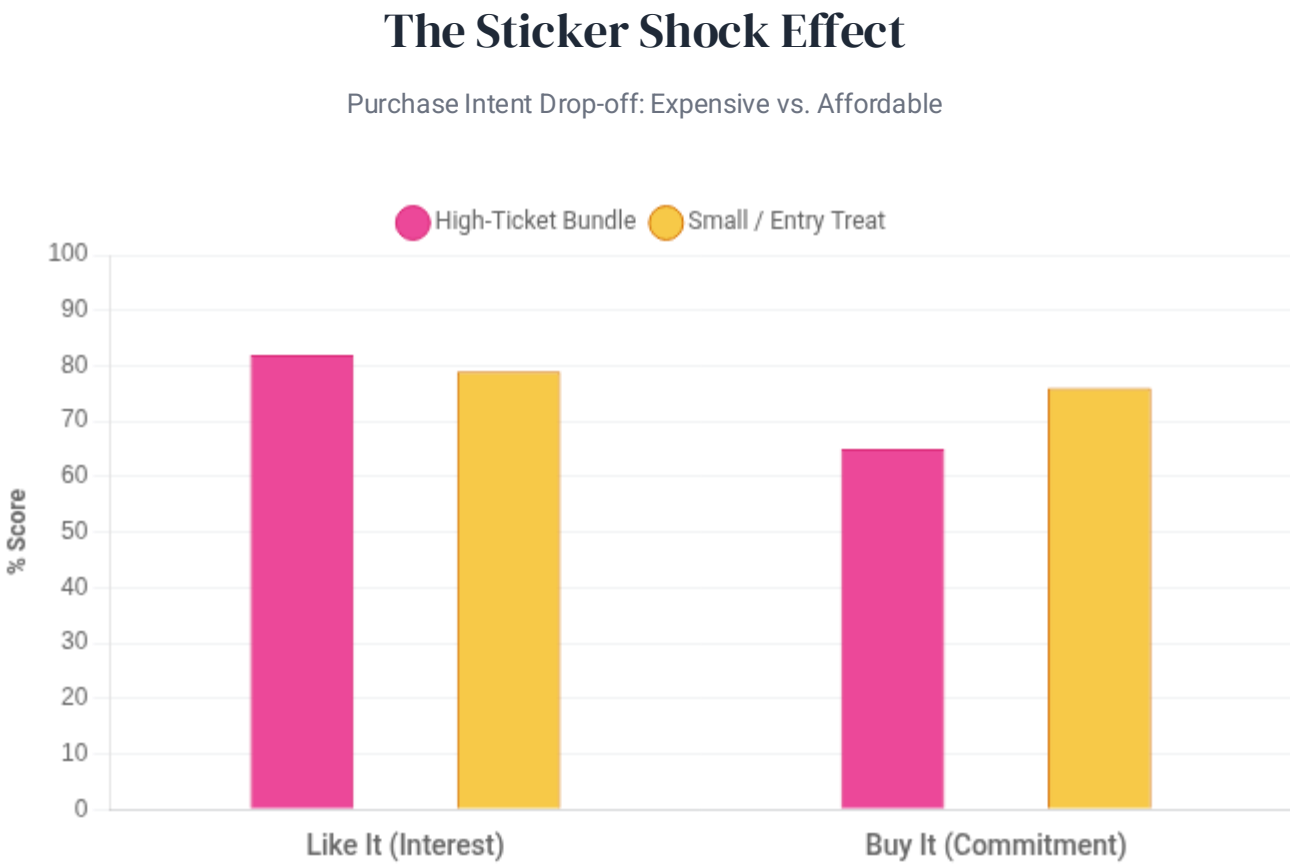
# Expensive = hesitation

## Sticker shock kills commitment.

Big bundles get the views, but they don't get the buys. When the total price hits a certain threshold, people bail at checkout. It's not that they don't want it—they just can't justify the hit to the wallet right now.

**10–15 pt**

Drop-off on big spend items



# Hype fades without habit

**Big launch energy, no repeat story = dead.**

Spectacle gets eyeballs, but utility gets the wallet. If consumers can't figure out **when** to use it by the second bite, you're just a one-hit wonder.

Anchor to a clear micro-moment (e.g., "The 3PM slump").

Portion cues beats loud packaging every time.

Make the second buy automatic, not a complex decision.

## The Habit Checklist

- ✓ **Defined Occasion**
  When do I actually eat this?
- ✓ **Portion Control**
  Does the size fit the vibe?
- ✓ **Emotional Permission**
  Is the guilt gone?
- ✓ **Price Accessibility**
  Can I afford this weekly?

# Bulk Kills Cadence

## Big pack = fewer happy moments.

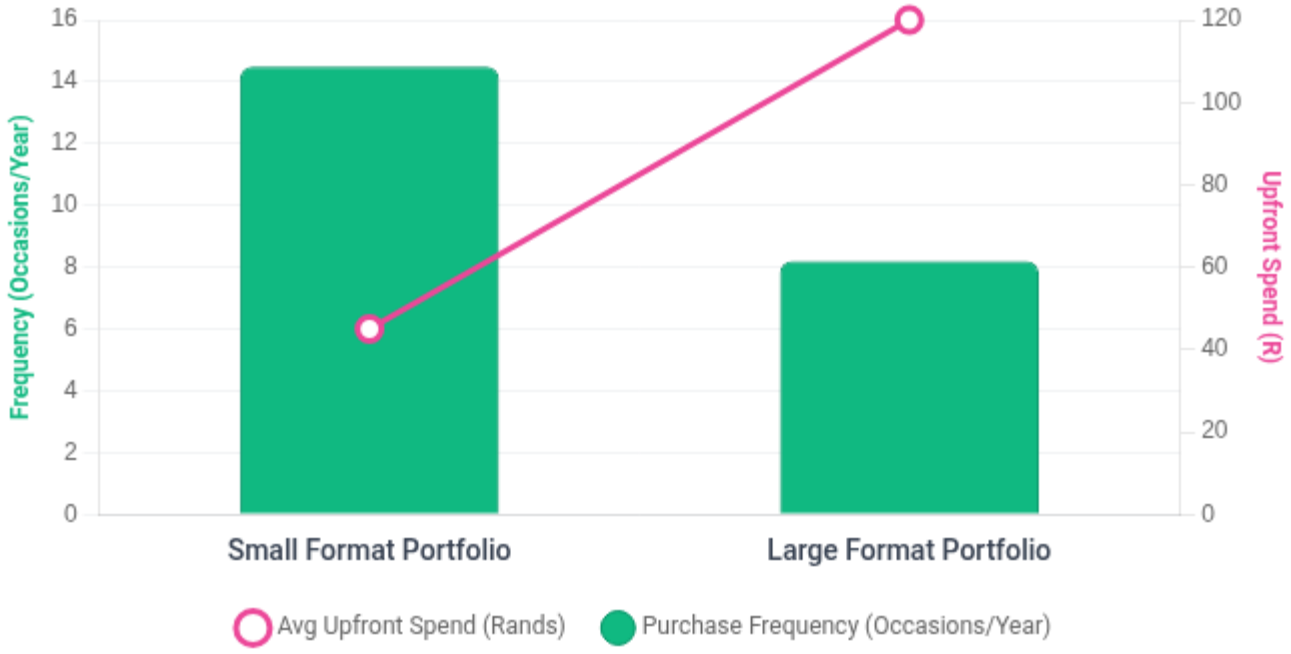
Large formats look efficient but reduce the number of happy moments and raise upfront spend. Smaller packs keep joy frequent and cash flow light.

Consumers hesitate at the high ticket price of bulk packs, opting instead for manageable, lower-cost frequency that fits their weekly envelope.

**-18%** **Frequency Drop**
where oversized packs dominate

### Impact of Pack Size on Behaviour

Annual Purchase Frequency vs. Avg Upfront Spend




*Source: Aggregated Innovatr Portfolio Analysis 2026*

# Discounts ≠ loyalty

## Price cuts get trial, not love.

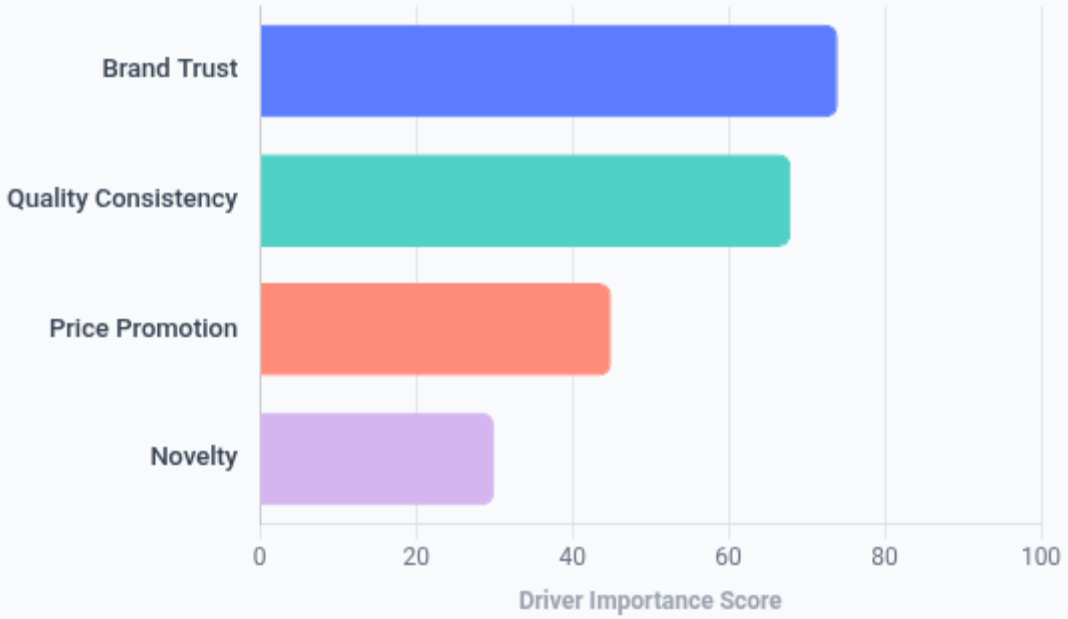
Promos might get a first date, but they don't get a second one. Real loyalty happens when they actually *feel* something for the brand, not just the coupon.

**The Trap:** Train them to wait for a sale, and you devalue the whole vibe.

**The Win:** Be fair, be consistent. That builds trust way faster than a 20% off sticker.

**The Reality:** Price gets attention. Emotion gets the ring.

### Why We Actually Stay Loyal




*Source: Innovatr Brand Tracking 2026*

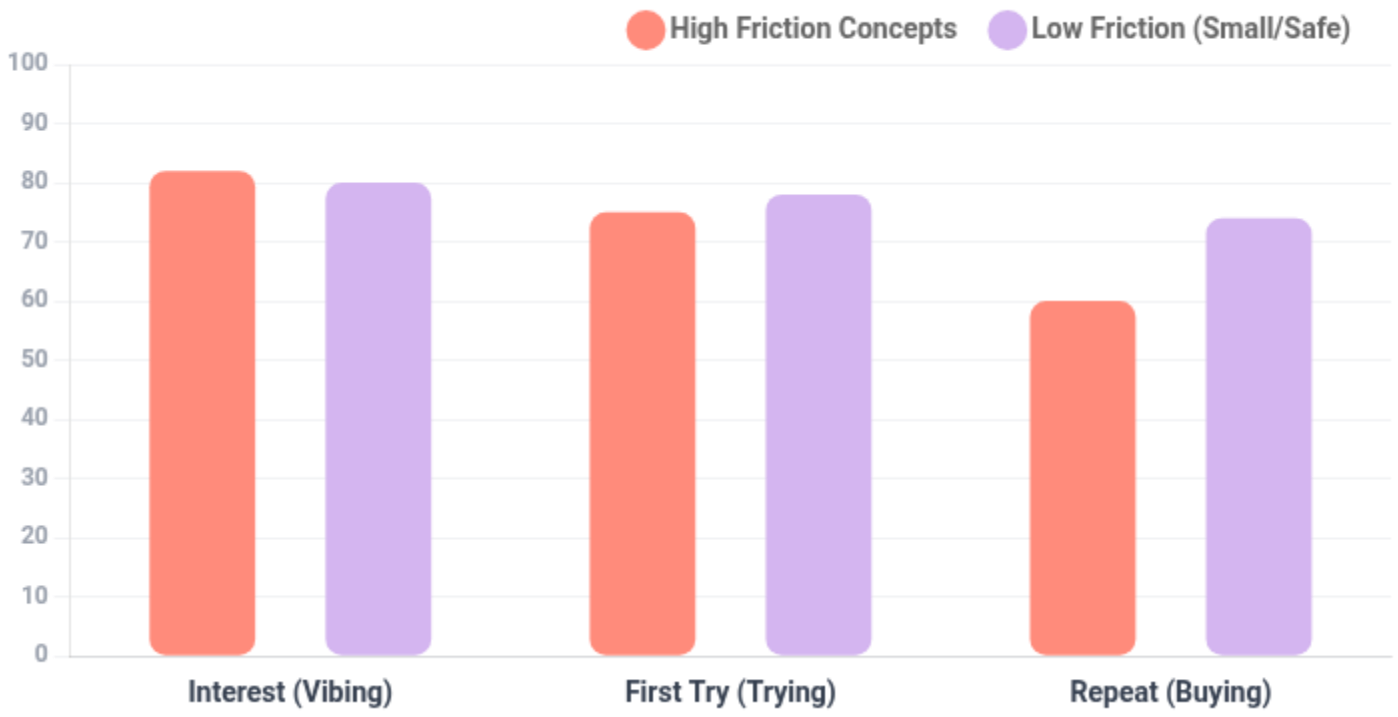
# The 10-15 point drop-off

## Liking to buying = the danger zone.

It’s easy to get a "like." It’s hard to get a swipe. High-commitment concepts often crash when it's time to choose. If you don't reassure them, they ghost you.

**10–15 pt**

**The "Ghosting Gap" (Interest to Repeat)**




*Source: Aggregated Innovatr Funnel Analysis 2026*

# So... what now?

4 strategic moves to capture the small-joy economy:

- Price architecture
- Smaller formats
- Occasion anchoring
- Portfolio balance

# Make pricing feel friendly

## Invite them in, don't scare them off.

Nobody wants to drop a fortune on a "maybe." Lower the barrier to entry with prices that say "why not?" instead of "are you sure?"

**67%**

of us are hacking the system to find cheaper rewards.

## The Pricing Playbook

### Keep it coin-friendly

R5 or R10 feels like "change." R14.99 feels like math. Remove the friction at the till.

### Don't force the bulk buy

Give us a fair deal on the regular size. We shouldn't have to buy a crate just to get value.

### Upsell the fans, not the newbies

Don't push premium on a first date. Save the fancy upgrades for the ones who are already obsessed.

### Kill the hidden fees

If there's fine print, we're out. The price on the sticker is exactly what we should pay.

# Small, but make it luxe

innovatr

## Minis should feel special, not cheap.

Don't just shrink it. Elevate it. If it's small, it better look, taste, and feel expensive.

**High Single Digits**

Repeat advantage for luxe minis vs. value packs.

### The "Pocket Bar" Moment

Fits in a pocket, hits the spot. It's a mood, not just a snack.

### The Minis Kit

Low risk, high reward. A flight of flavours for zero commitment issues.

### Sensory Overload

Texture, crunch, intensity. Make the small bite work harder than the big one.

### Vibe-Based Naming

Call it "Morning Lift" or "Brain Reset". Sell the feeling, not the size.

# Name the moment + say it's okay

## Give them permission to enjoy.

Vague vibes don't sell. Specific moments do. Validate the need for a break. Make indulgence feel like essential self-care, not a guilty secret.

**75%**

say treats = mental health support.

Occasion Frameworks

### The 'Switch Off' Moment

Post-work, post-school, post-chaos. The specific second they need a hard reset.

### Friday Night In

Cheaper than going out, better than doing nothing. The low-cost, high-joy ritual.

### Permission Words

Use words like "balance", "restore", "unwind". Kill the guilt before it even starts.

# Margin + frequency = both

**Hold high-margin treats for loyalists. Win new hearts with frequent affordable hits.**

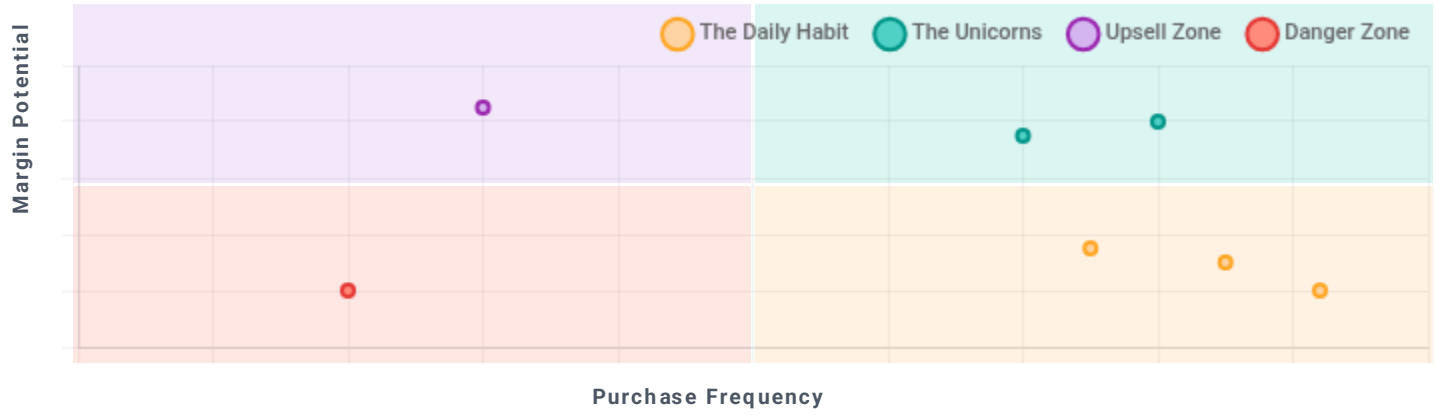
You need both engines running. Cheap daily habits keep the lights on. Premium splurges boost the bottom line. Don't pick sides—build a portfolio that does both.

## Habit > Receipt

Count visits, not just basket size. Repeat business is the new growth engine.

## The Playbook

- Anchor the Habit (Daily SKUs)
- Gate the Premium (Loyalist Only)
- Chase Repeats, Not Baskets



The Big Question

# Which treats would your customers never give up—even in a rough month?

Start there.

# Let's turn this into action

**We help you validate faster, launch smarter, and skip the expensive mistakes.**

### Test24 Basic

Which ideas win? Fast answers, real behaviour, zero fluff. Get your 75/81/53 benchmark.

### Test24 Pro

Turn 'likes' into buys. Deep diagnostics + optimization that protects your launch budget.

### Membership

Continuous intel for your whole team. Stop starting from scratch every time.

### Consult + Workshops

Big decisions need clarity. We help you choose, prioritize, and get everyone aligned.

You've spotted the small-joy shift.

→ **Let's help you own it. Talk to Innovatr**